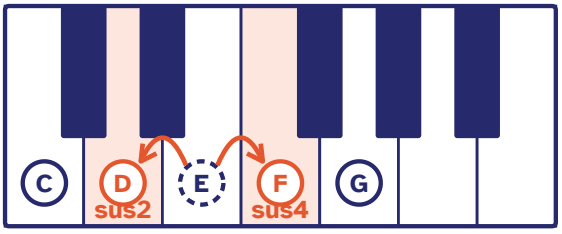
PART V · CHORDS · 6

# Colour chords

The 3rd is the chord's mood: major or minor, happy or sad. Slide it aside, take it away, or add one note, and a plain chord takes on a new colour. Five colours, all from C E G.

**THE SECRET**

**Move the 3rd, take it away, or add one note: five new colours.**

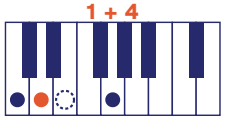



1. Start from **C E G**. The **E** (the 3rd) makes it major.
2. Slide the E up to the next letter, **F**: **Csus4**.
3. Or down to the letter below, **D**: **Csus2**. With no 3rd, the chord is neither major nor minor: it **hangs in the air**.

## Five colours, all on C

### Csus2

1 + 4



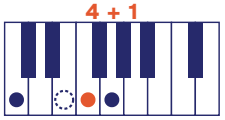
C D G

**open**

the 3rd steps down

### Csus4

4 + 1



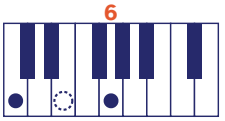
C F G

**floating**

the 3rd steps up

### C5

6



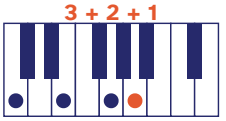
C G

**strong**

no 3rd at all

### C6

3 + 2 + 1



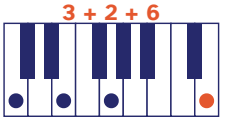
C E G A

**warm**

add the 6th

### Cadd9

3 + 2 + 6

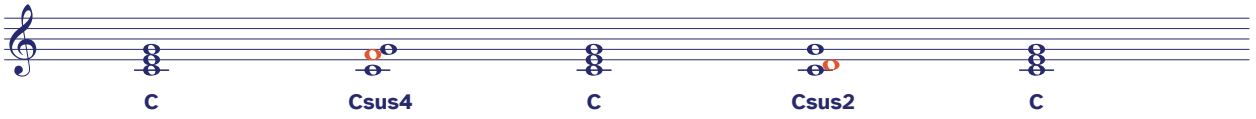


C E G D

**sparkly**

add the 9th on top

## Lean, then slide back




The red note leans, then slides back to E: F steps down, D steps up. Play it slowly: C, Csus4, C, Csus2, C. Guitarists love this shimmer.

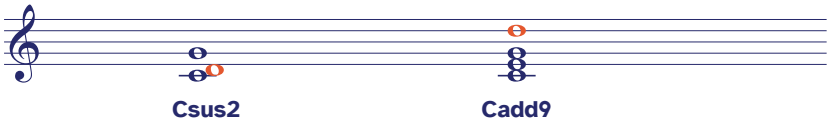
## On any root, the counts stay the same

| COLOUR | KEYS BETWEEN | ON C | ON G | ON F | ON D |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **sus2** | 1 + 4 | C D G | G A D | F G C | D E A |
| **sus4** | 4 + 1 | C F G | G C D | F B♭ C | D G A |
| **5** | 6 | C G | G D | F C | D A |
| **6** | 3 + 2 + 1 | C E G **A** | G B D **E** | F A C **D** | D F♯ A **B** |
| **add9** | 3 + 2 + 6 | C E G **D** | G B D **A** | F A C **G** | D F♯ A **E** |

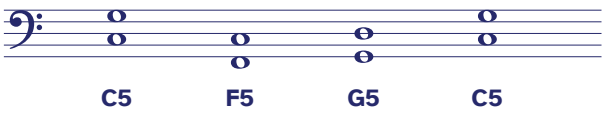
PART V · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

**sus**: the 3rd held up or down · **5**: no 3rd at all · **6** and **add9**: one note added on top. Csus means Csus4.

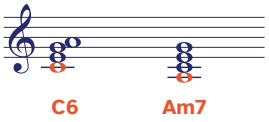
## Spot the difference




The same red D, two jobs. Csus2 throws the E out; Cadd9 keeps the E and puts the D on top.




**The power chord:** just the root and the 5th, played low in the left hand. With no 3rd it is neither happy nor sad, only **strong**: the sound of rock guitar. Play C5, F5, G5, C5 and drum the rhythm.




**C6 or Am7?** The same four notes, C E G A. The red bottom note decides: C at the bottom is **C6**; A at the bottom is **Am7**. More on the bass note in Slash chords, p. 131.

EXAMPLE 1

### Which colour is it? G C D




1. **Count the keys between:** G to C, then C to D.
2. **Find the card** with the same two numbers.
3. **Is there a 3rd (B)?** What has taken its place?

4 + 1, no B: G C D is **Gsus4**. Swap the C for **B** and you have G major.

GAME

### sus2, sus4 or add9?

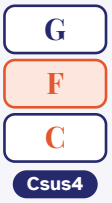
| 1 | 2 | 3 |
|---|---|---|
| C D G | C F G | C E G D |

In a sus chord the 3rd has moved; in an add chord nothing moved and a note was added.

Answer: 1 Csus2 · 2 Csus4 · 3 Cadd9.

PART V · CHORDS · 6 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

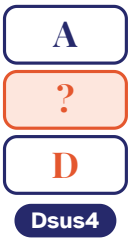



**Csus4, then C.**

Play C F G, then C E G. No 3rd, then a 3rd: floating, then bright.

EXAMPLE 2

## Build Dsus4

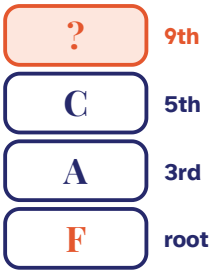



1. **Start with D major:** D F♯ A.
2. **sus4:** move the middle layer up to the next letter.
3. **Which key is it?**

F♯ moves up to **G**: Dsus4 is **D G A**.

EXAMPLE 3

## Build Fadd9




1. **Start with F major:** F A C, and keep every note.
2. **The 9th** is the 2nd, an octave up: which letter comes just after F?
3. **Put it on top.**

Fadd9: F A C **G**. Nothing moved; one note was added.

THINK OF IT Decorating the cake: a ribbon (the 6th) or a candle (the 9th) and it is still the same cake. Sus moves its middle layer; a power chord takes the middle layer out.

TRAP

× Calling Cadd9 a ninth chord: C9 also has the 7th (B♭). Add9 is just the triad plus the 9th (D on C), nothing else (The tower, p. 128).

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 113 · Seventh chords p. 122

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 6 · Online: Library › Chords